



Access Denied 3.30, BootLocker 7.65, 1Click & Lock 2.4, Security Storm Desktop Lock 2002 for Windows 9x/Me, Cyber Patrol 5.0, Snitch 1.2

Find them on the Mindware CD

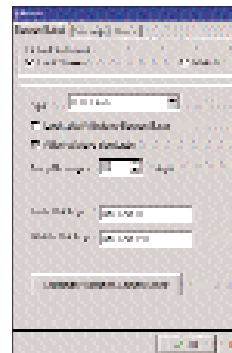
programs running at startup, etc. If no user logs in, it loads a default profile. To this default profile, we have added a command to log off at startup. Note that to create additional users, you will first need to delete this key from the registry.

This is sufficient to keep most people away from your computer, but if you want higher security, there are several third-party tools that provide excellent features. BootLocker (www.bootlocker.com) is one such utility that restricts access at various levels. You can use this as a login screen to Windows,

screensaver is to simply restart the system! Being executables, they are also vulnerable to viruses.

Workarounds for such vulnerabilities are simple—use more secure screensavers, after testing them thoroughly for all possible ways to kill it. Of course, you must also make a shortcut for it in the Startup folder otherwise someone can simply reboot your machine and disable the password. Couple this with a BIOS password and you have a fairly secure system.

For those who desperately want to get to your Windows, programs such as SSBy-pass (www.amecisco.com/ssbypass.htm) are readily available. It takes advantage of the Autorun facility for CDs, and kills the screensaver without having to provide the password. Unless you happen to interrupt the predator, you will never know that your system has been compromised. Thus, for



1Click & Lock is a good substitute for screensaver security

from a secure screensaver and Desktop lock. It can be launched at startup and runs in the system tray so that you can enable it when leaving your PC. It logs access and allows others to leave messages for you. Boot keys are disabled so that no one can access the PC from DOS or Safe Mode either. Also, the screensaver is optional—you may

// We have always been quite clear that Win95 and Win98 are not the systems to use if you are in a hostile security environment. We recommend Windows NT—for those environments //

or even when you leave your PC unattended for a while. It can even bring up a login screen for DOS. Access Denied (www.johnru.com) is a similar software that requests a username and password while booting. One great feature in this program is its ability to save short messages while the Desktop is locked. Thus, someone who wants to use your PC for a genuine purpose could leave a message for you to call him or her when you get to your PC.

Screensavers

Screensaver passwords are not as flawed as the Windows login—they are meant to protect an unattended Desktop from unauthorised access. However, these too are insecure because of their nature. Screensavers are simply executable programs. In fact, you can change the extension of any EXE file to SCR and load it as a screensaver! Thus, badly programmed or processor and RAM-intensive screensavers can often crash and give access to the Desktop. Amateur programmers can leave code that will allow simple key combinations such as [Alt] + [Tab], [Ctrl] + [Esc] and [Ctrl] + [Alt] + [Delete]. These problems plagued even the built-in screensavers on Windows 95 systems. The easiest way to bypass the

higher security, you will again have to fall back on third-party utilities such as Access Denied or Security Storm Desktop Lock 2002 (www.securitystorm.net). 1Click & Lock (www.softstack.com) is an interesting utility that combines all the functionality required

want to secure your desktop from access, but still view the programs running.

Network shares

Early users may remember that Windows was not originally intended to be used as a

Retrievable Passwords

Passwords on Windows systems are not safe. Any password you save within an application or anywhere within the system can be easily retrieved, or at least used on another PC. Some part of this will require good knowledge of Windows, for the rest, tools and utilities are readily available.

If you have the Auto-Complete feature for forms and passwords turned on in Internet Explorer, all this data is stored in the Windows Registry, under a single key. Anyone can simply export this key, transfer it to another machine and get access to your secure accounts on the Web. The data is not stored as plain text, but advanced users would even be able to decipher the passwords. You can turn off Auto-

Complete from **Control Panel > Internet Options > Content > AutoComplete**.

For applications such as e-mail and messenger clients, if you have saved the

account passwords in the application, they can be retrieved using software such as Revelation (www.snadboy.com). All one needs to do is point the cursor over the password field that displays asterisks to get the

actual password. Such software can be very useful when genuine users have forgotten their passwords, but the software does not distinguish between users—it will display the password to any user. For highest security, all passwords should be stored only in your head and nowhere else.

